

The Writing Process

The writing process is something that no two people do the same way. There is no "right way" or "wrong way" to write. It can be a very messy and fluid process, and the following is only a representation of commonly used steps. Remember you can come to the Writing Center for assistance at any stage in this process.

Steps of the Writing Process

Step 1: Prewriting

Think and Decide

- Make sure you understand your assignment. See [Research Papers](#) or [Essays](#)
- Decide on a topic to write about. See [Prewriting Strategies](#) and [Narrow your Topic](#)
- Consider who will read your work. See [Audience and Voice](#)
- Brainstorm ideas about the subject and how those ideas can be organized. Make an outline. See [Outlines](#)

Step 2: Research (if needed)

Search

- List places where you can find information.
- Do your research. See the many [KU Libraries](#) resources and [helpful guides](#)
- Evaluate your sources. See [Evaluating Sources](#) and [Primary vs. Secondary Sources](#)
- Make an outline to help organize your research. See [Outlines](#)

Step 3: Drafting

Write

- Write sentences and paragraphs even if they are not perfect.
- Create a thesis statement with your main idea. See [Thesis Statements](#)
- Put the information you researched into your essay accurately without plagiarizing. Remember to include both in-text citations and a bibliographic page. See [Incorporating References](#) and [Paraphrase and Summary](#)
- Read what you have written and judge if it says what you mean. Write some more.
- Read it again.
- Write some more.
- Read it again.
- Write until you have said everything you want to say about the topic.

Step 4: Revising

Make it Better

- Read what you have written again. See [Revising Content](#) and [Revising Organization](#)
- Rearrange words, sentences, or paragraphs into a clear and logical order.
- Take out or add parts.
- Do more research if you think you should.
- Replace overused or unclear words.
- Read your writing aloud to be sure it flows smoothly. Add transitions.

Step 5: Editing and Proofreading

Make it Correct

- Be sure all sentences are complete. See [Editing and Proofreading](#)

- Correct spelling, capitalization, and punctuation.
- Change words that are not used correctly or are unclear.
- Make sure you are using the appropriate style formatting.
 - [APA Formatting](#)
 - [Chicago Style Formatting](#)
 - [MLA Formatting](#)
- Have someone else check your work.